SERIAL ENTREPRENEUR



NILOTPAL BARUAH

Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, *51*
Entrepreneur/ Media Baroness

ACCOMPLISHMENT
The head of Northeast's biggest media empire, she's also a philanthropist

RINIKI BHUYAN SHARMA BELIEVES she was born with an entrepreneurial DNA. Riniki's father, Jadav Chandra Bhuyan, was a pioneering Assamese industrialist, and her entrepreneurial journey began while in college, learning the nuances of his business ventures. Simultaneously, she earned her master's in political science and also a law degree.

Marriage to Himanta Biswa Sarma in 2001, then an aspiring politician, forced Riniki to take a pause and concentrate on setting up a home and helping her husband build his political career. Parents from both sides were opposed—for different reasons—to this union of the two college lovebirds. Three months into the marriage, Himanta won the assembly election and the very next year became a minister.

For Riniki, it was time to take care of their two children—Nandil and Sukanya—till she finally decided to pursue what she always wanted to do—setting up diverse businesses. The first was an Assamese news channel in 2008, which became the foundation of the Northeast's largest media empire. It now has two news and two entertainment channels besides a newspaper and a magazine. She also turned into a filmmaker, producing several blockbuster Assamese films.

From media, in 2016, she moved to a socially conscious endeavour—the Golden Threads of Assam—which is aimed at not only preserving Muga, the trademark Assam silk, but showcasing it globally. In doing so, she has socially and financially empowered the women associated with weaving this indigenous thread. It's this focus on women's issues that motivated Riniki to start Aadya, a sanitary napkin manufacturing unit, in 2018. "It's a celebration of womanhood," she says. "The objective is to educate women on menstrual health and hygiene and break the taboos...."

Last year, she ventured into the education sector by setting up Vandya International, the biggest school in the Northeast in terms of infrastructure. Now, she is all set to enter the hospitality industry by starting a luxury abode for nature lovers.

Along with the series of successes came the criticism—everything she achieved was attributed to her husband who remained a powerful minister before becoming Assam's chief minister in 2021. "My companies have never done any business with the Assam government," she says. "I've inherited business skills from my father. I don't need political patronage to make money or become successful." ■

-Kaushik Deka

GOLDEN WORDS

"Never leave a task half done. Play deaf to critics"

PLAYER & PATRON
Riniki represented Assam in lawn tennis at the national level. Recently, she has revived the state's defunct basketball association